instrumental in establishing the National Centre for Biological Sciences under the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research. On the other hand, Dr Paul has had a long, distinguished career as a medical expert and a public health expert, serving for over a decade as the head of the Paediatrics department at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), Delhi. The duo began to study the behavioural patterns of the new virus, which, to them, seemed eerily similar to the coronavirus family. By the first week of January 2020, both had collated more information about the seafood market, which appeared to be the origin point of the infections. As a biologist, Prof. VijayRaghavan knew that the origin of the virus would play a crucial role in determining its core nature. The report he scribbled had details like:

> [T]he Huanan market sold bats (a known super-spreader of diseases which transmit to humans, chicken, cats, dogs, marmots, snakes, seafood and other animals). Currently it seems that the market has been closed for environmental sanitisation and disinfection. Several vendors in the Huanan market are primarily said to have been infected. A river separates the market and the Wuhan Institute of Virology lab. It is not clear if all infections are reported from the market side of the river. Was it a zoonotic spill over or a lab leak, must be investigated![9]

Dr Paul observed, ‘The market was located next to a mainstream, busy train station which served as a major transportation hub at the centre of China’s domestic train routes.’ In his report, he also noted patterns of the clinical symptoms which were observed in the 27 cases reported till 1 January 2020; which were fever and difficulty in breathing, specifically in those who demonstrated bilateral lung infiltrates on chest x-rays. Much to their relief, they were also hearing that there had been no evidence of human-to-human transmission. In fact, no infection of hospital staff had been reported till date. Spread of the disease in hospital staff is generally one of the initial patterns observed in human-to-human transmission. In the first week of January, the Wuhan municipal health commissioner released a statement that laboratory testing was underway to determine respiratory pathogens.[10]

They communicated their findings to senior officials in the PMO who then decided it was time the prime minister was briefed without further delay. Principal Secretary Dr P.K. Mishra and Cabinet Secretary Rajiv